
THE INVESTOR'S HANDBOOK

The Dubai Property Investment Guide

Everything an overseas investor needs to buy, own, and earn from real estate in Dubai: ownership rules, the buying process, costs, yields, and residency, in one place.

0%

INCOME & CAPITAL
GAINS TAX

5–8%

TYPICAL GROSS
RENTAL YIELDS

AED 2M

GOLDEN VISA
THRESHOLD

WELCOME

Why investors are choosing Dubai

Dubai has become one of the world's most active property markets: a tax-friendly, freehold-enabled city where overseas buyers can own real estate outright, earn strong rental income, and qualify for long-term residency. This guide walks you through the entire journey, from understanding ownership rights to closing a deal and earning your first yield.

Tax efficiency

No annual property tax, no capital gains tax, and no tax on rental income for individual owners.

Freehold ownership

Foreign nationals can own property outright in designated freehold zones across the city.

Residency access

A qualifying property investment can unlock a renewable 2-year or 10-year UAE residence visa.

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CHAPTER 01

Why Dubai: the market in numbers

A decade of population growth, infrastructure investment, and investor-friendly reform has made Dubai one of the most liquid and resilient property markets globally.

TRANSACTIONS 2025

270K+

▲ 20% year on year

TOTAL VALUE

AED 917B

all-time record

AVG. GROSS YIELD

6.8%

across prime areas

POPULATION

4.0M+

▲ growing ~5% / yr



A market built on fundamentals

Demand is driven by genuine population inflow: professionals relocating, families settling, and businesses establishing regional headquarters. In 2025 property investment topped AED 680 billion across some 259,000 deals, the busiest year on record. Dubai pairs this with world-class infrastructure, safety, and a stable currency pegged to the US dollar.

Liquidity & transparency

Every transaction is registered with the Dubai Land Department (DLD), and developer payments for off-plan projects are protected in regulated escrow accounts, giving overseas buyers a clear, traceable process.



The currency advantage

The UAE dirham is pegged to the US dollar (1 USD ≈ AED 3.67), removing currency-conversion guesswork and giving dollar-based investors price stability over the long term.

What to watch in 2026: a heavy delivery pipeline is adding supply, so a more selective, slower-growth year than 2025 is expected, so buy on fundamentals, not momentum. Source: Dubai Land Department full-year 2025 data.

CHAPTER 02

Ownership & legal framework

Understanding where and how you can own is the foundation of any Dubai investment. The rules are clear, and overseas buyers are explicitly welcome.

Freehold**Freehold ownership**

You own the property and the land it sits on, in perpetuity. Available to all nationalities within designated freehold zones. Your name is registered on the title deed at the DLD.

Leasehold**Leasehold ownership**

The right to use a property for a fixed term, typically up to 99 years. Common in select communities. The freehold reverts to the master developer at the end of the term.

Popular freehold zones for investors

Dubai Marina

Waterfront towers, strong short-let demand.

Downtown Dubai

Burj Khalifa district, premium capital values.

Palm Jumeirah

Iconic island, ultra-prime villas & apartments.

Business Bay

Central, mixed-use, high rental turnover.

JVC

Affordable entry, among the highest yields.

Dubai Hills Estate

Family villas, parks, golf, steady growth.

**You don't need to be a resident to buy**

Overseas buyers can purchase remotely. A passport is the only identification required; no UAE residence visa or local sponsor is needed to take ownership of a freehold property.

CHAPTER 03

The buying process, step by step

A typical ready-property purchase completes in 4–6 weeks. Off-plan reservations can be secured in a matter of days.

1

Define your strategy & budget

Decide between off-plan and ready, capital growth versus rental yield, and your all-in budget including fees. Your broker shortlists matching units.

2

View & select the property

Tour in person or via video. For off-plan, review the floor plan, payment plan, and the developer's track record and escrow account.

3

Reserve & sign the MOU

Sign a Memorandum of Understanding (Form F) and pay a deposit, typically 10% for ready property. The unit is taken off the market.

4

Apply for the NOC

For ready resale, the developer issues a No Objection Certificate confirming all service charges are settled and the unit can transfer.

5

Transfer at the DLD

Both parties meet at a DLD-approved trustee office. The balance is paid, fees are settled, and a new title deed is issued in your name on the spot.

6

Handover & registration

Collect the keys, register utilities (DEWA), and, if leasing, list the unit. Your broker can manage tenanting and short-let setup.



Before you start: investor checklist

Valid passport · budget including ~7% in fees · proof of funds · developer NOC (resale) · a DLD trustee appointment. Have these ready and a purchase moves quickly.

CHAPTER 04

Costs, fees & taxes

Budget for roughly 6–8% in one-off transaction costs on top of the purchase price. There are no recurring property or income taxes.

ONE-OFF PURCHASE COSTS	PAID TO	TYPICAL AMOUNT
DLD transfer fee	Dubai Land Department	4% + AED 580
Agency commission	Brokerage	2% + 5% VAT
Title deed issuance	DLD	AED 250
Trustee / registration office	DLD trustee	AED 4,200
Developer NOC (resale)	Developer	AED 500–5,000
Mortgage registration (if financed)	DLD	0.25% of loan

Ongoing costs

Service charges: annual fee per sq ft for building maintenance, typically AED 10–30/sq ft depending on the community and amenities.

Utilities (DEWA): water, electricity & cooling, billed monthly to the occupant.

The tax position

- 0% No annual property tax
- 0% No capital gains tax
- 0% No personal income tax on rent



Worked example: AED 2,000,000 apartment

DLD fee ≈ AED 80,580 · Agency ≈ AED 42,000 · Registration ≈ AED 4,450. All-in transaction cost ≈ **AED 127,000** (≈6.4%), payable once at transfer.

CHAPTER 05

Payment plans & financing

Off-plan developers offer staged payment plans that lower the upfront capital required. Mortgages are available to residents and non-residents alike.

Common off-plan payment structures

60 / 40

60% during construction in instalments, 40% on handover. The most common balanced plan.

20 / 80

Just 20% down, 80% on completion. Lower entry, ideal for capital-growth plays.

Post-handover

Pay a portion for 1–3 years after you receive the keys, often while already earning rent.

Mortgage financing at a glance

CRITERION	UAE RESIDENTS	NON-RESIDENTS
Max. loan-to-value	Up to 80%	50–65%
Typical term	Up to 25 years	Up to 25 years
Indicative rate	From ~4.0% p.a.	From ~4.75% p.a.
Max. age at maturity	65–70 years	65–70 years

Indicative only. Rates and LTV limits vary by bank, property type, and applicant profile. Speak to a mortgage advisor for a tailored quote.



Why payment plans matter for ROI

Staged payments mean your capital is deployed gradually while the asset appreciates, improving your return on actual cash invested before handover.

CHAPTER 06

ROI & rental yields by area

Gross yields vary by community: emerging areas tend to offer higher rental returns, while prime districts favour long-term capital appreciation.

COMMUNITY	PROFILE	AVG. PRICE / SQFT	GROSS YIELD
JVC Jumeirah Village Circle	High-yield, affordable	AED 1,150	8.4%
Business Bay Central, mixed-use	Balanced	AED 1,720	6.9%
Dubai Marina Waterfront towers	Strong short-let	AED 1,950	6.5%
Dubai Hills Estate Family villas	Capital growth	AED 2,050	5.8%
Downtown Dubai Burj Khalifa district	Prime	AED 2,650	5.4%
Palm Jumeirah Iconic island	Ultra-prime	AED 3,400	5.0%

Gross vs. net yield

Gross yield is annual rent ÷ purchase price. Net yield deducts service charges, management, and vacancy, typically landing 1–1.5 percentage points below gross.

Short-let upside

Licensed holiday-home letting in tourist hotspots like Marina and Downtown can lift gross returns above long-term tenancy, with higher management involvement.

Indicative averages; for context, 2025 city-wide prices ran around AED 1,558/sqft in the primary market and AED 1,332/sqft on the secondary market. Actual figures vary by building, unit, and view. Verify current data before committing. Source: DLD 2025.

CHAPTER 07

Off-plan vs. ready property

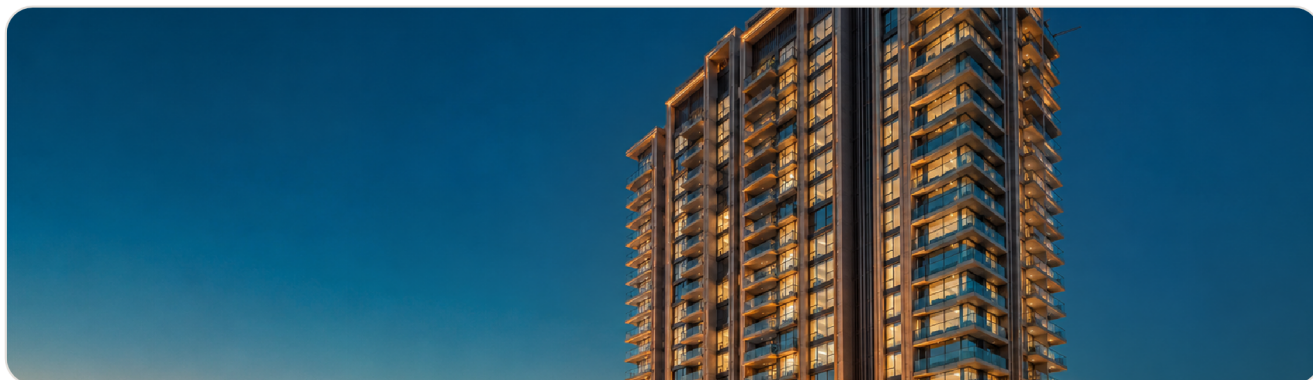
Both routes have a place in a portfolio. The right choice depends on your timeline, cash flow, and whether you prioritise growth or immediate income.

Off Plan**Buy before completion****BEST FOR CAPITAL GROWTH**

- ✓ Lower entry price & staged payment plans
- ✓ Potential appreciation before handover
- ✓ Brand-new unit, full developer warranty
- No rental income until completion
- Reliant on developer delivery timeline

Ready**Buy a completed home****BEST FOR IMMEDIATE INCOME**

- ✓ Rental income from day one
- ✓ See the exact unit, view & finish
- ✓ Faster path to a residence visa
- Higher upfront capital required
- Less scope for pre-handover gains

**A common hybrid strategy**

Many investors hold a ready unit for steady cash flow while taking an off-plan position for growth, diversifying across timeline and risk within a single portfolio.

CHAPTER 08

The Golden Visa & residency

A qualifying property investment can unlock long-term UAE residency for you and your family: one of the strongest non-financial reasons to invest.

10-Year

AED 2M+

Property valued at AED 2 million or more qualifies for the renewable 10-year Golden Visa. There is no minimum down-payment; mortgaged and off-plan properties now qualify once the DLD valuation reaches AED 2M.

2-Year

From AED 400K

A lower-value property supports a renewable 2-year investor visa. Dubai removed the former AED 750,000 floor in 2026; joint owners now need AED 400,000 each, assessed on the DLD valuation. Confirm the current rule before relying on it.

What residency gives you

Sponsor your family

Include your spouse and children under your residence visa.

Live & bank locally

Open UAE bank accounts and reside in the country freely.

No minimum stay

The Golden Visa remains valid without a continuous-residence requirement.

**Eligibility runs on the DLD valuation**

Eligibility is assessed on a current Dubai Land Department valuation certificate, not only the deed price. Applications typically process in 7–10 business days and cover your spouse and children. We confirm eligibility before you commit.

CHAPTER 09

Frequently asked questions

Q Can I buy property in Dubai as a foreigner?

Yes. Any nationality can own freehold property outright within Dubai's designated freehold zones. You do not need to be a resident or have a local sponsor.

Q Do I need to travel to Dubai to complete a purchase?

Not necessarily. Purchases can be completed remotely through a Power of Attorney, with viewings done by video. Many overseas investors buy without setting foot in the country.

Q How much should I budget beyond the purchase price?

Allow roughly 6–8% in one-off transaction costs: the 4% DLD transfer fee, ~2% agency commission, and registration charges. There are no annual property taxes thereafter.

Q Is my money safe when buying off-plan?

Developer payments for registered off-plan projects are held in DLD-regulated escrow accounts and released against construction milestones, protecting buyers' funds.

Q Can I get a mortgage as a non-resident?

Yes. Several UAE banks lend to non-residents, typically up to 50–65% loan-to-value. Terms depend on the bank, the property, and your financial profile.

Q What return can I realistically expect?

Gross rental yields commonly range from 5% in prime districts to over 8% in high-yield communities, alongside potential capital appreciation. Net yields run slightly lower after costs.

Q Can the property get me a residence visa?

A lower-value property can support a renewable 2-year investor visa (the former AED 750,000 floor was removed in 2026), while AED 2M+ qualifies for the 10-year Golden Visa, now including mortgaged and off-plan units, assessed on the DLD valuation and processed in about 7–10 days. Rules changed through 2025–26, so confirm the current thresholds.

LET'S TALK

Ready to start your Dubai investment?

Our RERA-registered advisors will shortlist properties to your strategy, walk you through every step, and handle the paperwork end to end, wherever you are in the world.



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